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Assignment 3: Reflections and Lessons from the Internship (Hypothetical + Research-based)

Company: Lululemon Athletica

Internship Type: Hypothetical Global Internship Program (From research)

1. Overview of the Internship

For this assignment, I participated in a hypothetical 10-week global internship at Lululemon's headquarters in Vancouver, with an emphasis on strategy and innovation. I used publicly available data such as reports and interviews to explore how Lululemon operates as a retailer.

Key responsibilities included:

- Engaging with new market entry strategies
- Analyzing product innovation (such as their new knit shoe model)
- Researching internal leadership and company culture

2. New Learnings

- Lululemon utilizes vertical integration
 - Lululemon owns its own design and production, in turn, they have increased control, feedback loops, and brand consistency.
- Culture is led by innovation
 - Innovation is a core component in every team/department, not just the product
- Leadership & Empowerment
 - Employees at all levels are encouraged to use growth tools and personal leadership development

3. Surprises

- Lululemon uses their culture as a strategy
 - Utilize leadership training, feedback, and focus on team wellness
- Metrics
 - They have KPIs for sales/finances, but also prioritize guest impact, employee energy, and community engagement
- Expansion

- Lululemon's strategy in Europe is highly data-informed

4. Career

This research enhanced my understanding of:

- Purpose-driven strategy with real-world examples from a top retailer
- Retail innovation and culture building, especially in high-performance environments

These insights are highly transferable to roles in retail sales and leadership roles in this industry.

5. EMPAC Model Reflections

- Experience
 - Shown through immersive guest experiences and employee engagement
- Action
 - Employees are empowered to act, lead, and be problem solvers
- Connection
 - Community and team loyalty
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Lululemon is not just a basic retailer, shown through its emphasis on culture, innovation, and purpose. I now feel more confident in analyzing modern retail strategy and evaluating future employers, leadership styles, and business models.

Fun Fact: I met the CEO of Lululemon at the Santa Cruz Iron Man a few weeks ago, a great reminder that leadership and lifestyle align in purpose-driven companies!